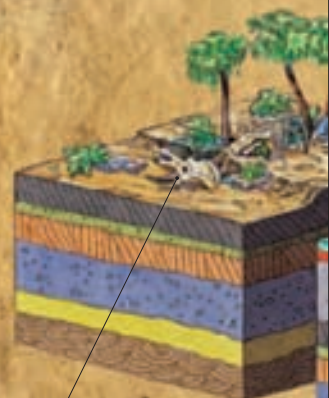


All about fossils

Almost everything we know about prehistoric animals comes from fossils. A fossil is the preserved remains or trace of an ancient animal or plant. The word “fossil” comes from the Latin word *fossilis*. That means “dug up,” and that’s how some fossils are discovered, although most are exposed by erosion. Most fossilized animals have lain buried for millions of years.



A dinosaur dies and falls into the muddy bank of a river.

▲ IT'S IN THE DETAIL *Complete fossilized skeletons are rare, but when found they provide a huge amount of information for fossil hunters (paleontologists).*



DID YOU KNOW?

- Fossils are usually found in rock but may also be found in mud or gravel.
- The parts of an animal most likely to fossilize are the hard parts: the bones or teeth or a creature's shell.
- Teeth are among the most commonly found fossils.
- The oldest fossils are stromatolites (mounds of rock made by sea-dwelling bacteria). These have been dated to 3.5 billion years ago.

TYPES OF FOSSIL

Fossils can be sorted, or classified, into different types, depending on how they formed. All take millions of years to form—fossilization is not quick.



Total preservation If an insect or spider was caught in the sticky sap released by a tree such as a pine, it may be preserved complete. Creatures that are millions of years old have been preserved in fossilized tree resin (known as amber) in this way.



Mineralization Dinosaurs, like us, had hard bones, and sometimes just these parts of an animal are preserved—though not as bone, which is replaced over time with minerals to form rock. Rock has to be carefully removed to expose the fossils.